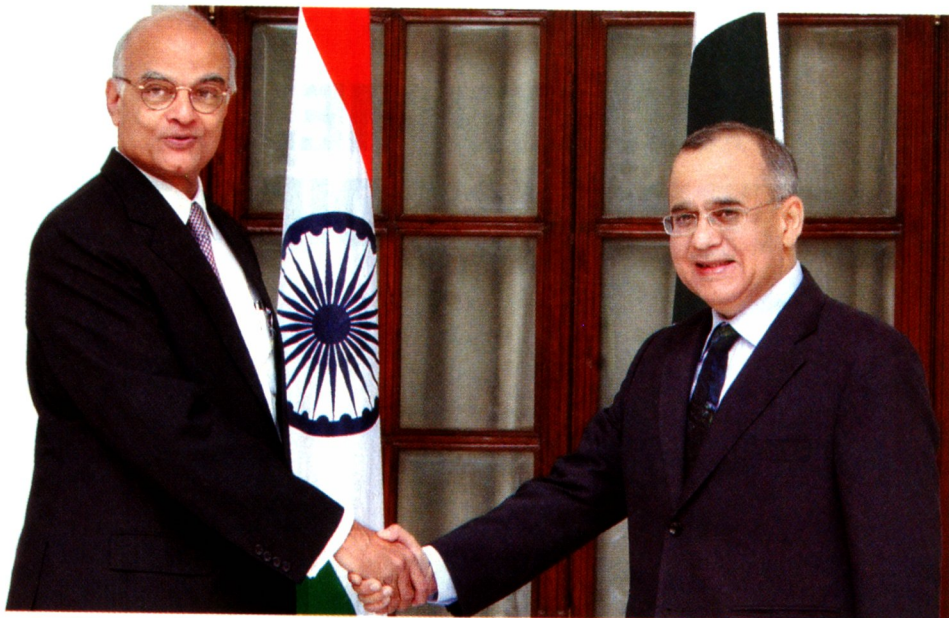




BLAST FROM THE PAST:
Menon (left) and Bashir

attack on the Indian mission in Kabul on July 7. "All our information in the ongoing investigations points to elements in Pakistan being behind the blast. The composite dialogue process is under stress and has affected the prospects of the relationship with Pakistan unless we show results," he said.

The statement assumes significance as it tears apart the charade of normalcy that the two countries had displayed when the Pakistani Foreign Minister Shah Mehmood Qureshi visited Delhi last month for bilateral talks. It was hoped that the new Government in Pakistan would initiate steps to improve ties with India, but the spurt in terrorist violence from Pakistan indicates that only the reverse is true.

by Saurabh Shukla

In No Man's Land

DELHI Away from the headlines that screamed about the trust vote in Parliament, India talked tough quietly with Pakistan on July 21 as the aftermath of the Kabul suicide attack played out on the bilateral talks

between the two neighbours. The dialogue between Indian Foreign Secretary Shiv Shankar Menon and his counterpart Salman Bashir were cordial but strained as the usually composed Menon told Bashir that the attack

had put enormous pressure on the dialogue process and Pakistan has to come clean on the terrorism issue.

Menon, a former Indian envoy to Pakistan who was the architect of the failed joint anti-terror mechanism between the two sides, was candid in informing Bashir of Pakistan's role in the

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

With crores of rupees changing hands before the confidence vote, the Opposition is demanding that a windfall tax be imposed on MPs who took money to switch loyalties and that the UPA be renamed the United Poachers' Alliance.

VOICES

"The PMO has become the biggest counter for political bargain and the patent promoter of horse-trading."

Ravi Shankar Prasad, BJP spokesman

"The nuclear deal is our passport to the international community. If you have a passport, only then can you apply for a visa to another country."

Pranab Mukherjee, external affairs minister

"The UPA is like a patient in the ICU room. The first question everyone asks is whether he is going to survive or not."

L.K. Advani, leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha

"Earlier low food prices justified the subsidies of the rich. Today high food prices are used to justify these. Heads I win, tails you lose. This is how one has one's cake and eats it too."

Nirupam Sen, Indian ambassador to the UN addressing the UN General Assembly

"Even if he (grand uncle and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi) wants to reconcile with us, people around him will never let it happen."

Dayanidhi Maran, DMK MP and former Union minister